Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Elizabeth Barrett Browning's "[And therefore if to love can be desert]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's opening conditional, her "if-then" (lines 1-2), is followed by a litany of negative, essentially self-deprecating, comments, which is replaced by something of a positive certainty in line 11's turn include

alliteration,
allusion,
anaphora,
aphaeresis,
apostrophe,
enjambment,
iambic pentameter,
imagery,
internal rhyme,
litany,
litotes,
masculine rhyme,
metaphor,
meter,
octave,
parallelism,
ploce,
rhetorical question,
rhyme scheme,
sestet,
simile,
sonnet,
speaker,
theme,
tone, and
volta.

The young literary critic's approach to delineating the speaker's shift from what is essentially a question through to an answer should reflect upon the conditional offered in the first two lines of the sonnet: "And therefore if to love can be desert, / **[then]** I am not all unworthy." Instrumental in the framing of the speaker's litany of self-deprecation that follows and that makes up a good portion of the poem are both the litotes ("not all unworthy") found in line 2 and that which follows the volta that introduces the eleventh line of the sonnet: "because I love thee, I obtain / From that same love this vindicating grace" (lines 11-12), which proposes that in spite of and, indeed, because of the speaker's failings, she is worthy to love her beloved.

That the contestant follows the speaker's progress through the incremental self-deprecation—"Cheeks as pale as" (line 2); "trembling knees that fail" (line 3); her song-making (perhaps, her versification) no longer strong enough to outdo the nightingale's "melancholy music" (line 8), culminating with "I am not of thy worth nor for thy place!" (line 10)—reveals the contestant's understanding; however, the recognition that the speaker's argument opens with a figure of speech (litotes) that anticipates the redeeming turn in logic (the volta) serves as evidence that the contestant understands Barrett Browning's ploy.